

Q I want to take a vacation. What's the best time for me to go?

For most women, the best time is during their second trimester. This is when you're most likely to be enjoying your pregnancy, have increased energy, and feel sick less often. You're more likely to feel comfortable with the idea of traveling and leaving your creature comforts behind. During your first trimester you might feel nauseous and tired, and there is generally a greater risk of miscarrying your baby. During your third trimester you're likely to feel more uncomfortable during travel and most tired. On top of that, if anyone thinks there's a risk you might go into labor, you may have trouble arranging travel to and from your destination since airlines might be reluctant to have you on board a flight.

Q What's the latest point in my pregnancy that I can fly?

There's generally nothing dangerous about flying during pregnancy, as long as you're in a pressurized air cabin (all large planes are pressurized, but small island hops might not be). If you have high blood pressure, are very anemic, or you've had a previous miscarriage, you may be advised to avoid flying. It's best to ask your doctor for advice that's right for you.

There are also the airline's rules, which vary depending on the company. In general, they won't take you after around 36 weeks pregnant—although this isn't a hard-and-fast rule—or a few weeks earlier if you're pregnant with twins or multiples (remember, these are the dates for your return). Some airlines will make an exception. If you're traveling during

your third trimester, almost all will ask for a letter from your doctor to say that you can travel. Make sure you carry this letter with you if this applies to you: the airline has the right to refuse to let you board the plane if your due date or health are in doubt. They want to avoid having a pregnant woman in labor midflight.

Q Are there any types of vacation I should avoid while I'm pregnant?

Avoid any vacation that might put a lot of physical strain on your body, for example those involving activities that place you in danger of high impact, that restrict your oxygen intake, or that raise your core body temperature.

This means that scuba diving vacations are temporarily off the agenda, as are skiing

Q Is there an increased risk of thrombosis for me during a “long-haul” flight?

Any flight longer than five hours is considered “long haul” for people at risk of thrombosis (blood clots)—which includes pregnant women.

During a long flight, blood can pool in your veins (usually in your legs) and cause clots. Before you book, check with your doctor that you're not at an especially high risk of developing thrombosis when you fly, for example if you suffer from diabetes, high blood pressure, or high cholesterol. During any flight, whether or not it's long haul, call a member of the cabin crew immediately

if you feel dizzy—the oxygen circulating in the cabin can be a bit thin and you may need a boost from an oxygen mask. To minimize the risk of thrombosis when you're in the air, follow these tips (see right).

Formation of blood clots This begins when fatty deposits called atheromas form. The growing atheroma reduces blood flow and oxygen to the tissues and then ruptures, causing a clot to form.



» **Wear support hose** or compression flight socks to help keep your circulation flowing while you're airborne. Most pharmacies sell these.



» **Walk up and down** the aisle every 30 minutes if the seat-belt sign is off. Do gentle stretches if there is space to do so at the end of the aisle.



» **Drink plenty of water** during the flight. It will keep you hydrated and force you to take regular trips to the bathroom (making you get up and move around).



» **Ask for an aisle seat** so you can stretch your legs (or, even better, pay for extra leg room if your airline offers it as an option).



» **Point and flex your ankles** from time to time while you're sitting. Move each foot round in a circular motion to help keep your circulation flowing.



» **Wear loose clothes** and shoes or sandals that will accommodate swollen feet. Take your shoes off while you're seated to make your feet less constricted.